

SHROUDED IN SECRECY

mystery cults



▲ Eleusinian initiation

In this plaque, a worshipper is initiated into the cult of the Eleusinian Mysteries. Part of the ceremony re-created the search by the goddess Demeter for her daughter Kore, who had been kidnapped by Hades and taken to the underworld.

Commoners of the ancient Roman world were denied participation in the public temple rituals, so many turned to mystery cults—unofficial religions that would accept them. Mystery cults offered a direct relationship with the gods, the hope of a better afterlife, and social bonds.

Mystery cults thrived in part because the Romans were unusually open to foreign religions. Their main quality was secrecy, both around initiation into the cult, which acted as a mystical rebirth, and its rituals. The most venerable cult was the Eleusinian Mysteries, which honored Demeter, the goddess of harvest, fertility, and cycles of life and death. The Mysteries centered on the town of Eleusis, near Athens. Their main ceremony was the annual eight-day festival during which would-be initiates engaged in a simulated descent into Hades (the underworld) through a dark wood, from which they were rescued by priests with torches.

► Cybele with a cymbal

The goddess Cybele, also called Magna Mater (great mother), is shown on this votive plaque. She holds a cymbal and has two lions with her, symbols of her links to the wildness of nature and the noisy frenzy of her worship.



► Dionysian rites

The frescoes in the Villa of Mysteries in Pompeii show an initiation into the cult of Dionysus. One rite involved reenacting the marriage of Dionysus to the mortal Ariadne, complete with a naked *maenad* (female follower) dancing.

Wine and lunar raptures

Initiates of the Italian cult of Dionysus, the Greek god of wine, engaged in *teletai*, rituals involving ecstatic dancing and singing, while carrying *thyrsos*, fennel wands wrapped in ivy and topped with pinecones. The cult's activities particularly concerned the Roman authorities, who in 186 BCE tried to ban it.

Similar worries were expressed about the Cult of Magna Mater, derived from the worship of the Asiatic moon goddess Cybele and her consort Attis. Her worshippers, the *Korybantes*, used clashing cymbals to rouse themselves to a euphoric frenzy, and the most enthusiastic male worshippers even castrated themselves.

Percussion and sacrifice

The cult of the Egyptian goddess Isis had its own temple in Rome by 65 CE. Its priests valued ritual purity highly, shaving their heads and dressing in linen, although they, too, engaged in noisy rites using the *sistrum*, a percussion instrument.

Most widespread and secretive of all was the cult of Mithras. Emerging in the 1st century CE, it derived indirectly from Persian beliefs and its main ritual was the *tauroctony* (bull sacrifice),

in which the blood of the dying animal symbolized purity and rebirth. The all-male members were graded into seven ranks, from *Corax* (Raven) to *Pater* (Father), and initiates worshipped Mithras in *mithraea*, underground rectangular temples simulating caves. Mithraism flourished throughout the Roman Empire, but it, along with all the other mystery cults, was suppressed when the Empire became Christian in the 4th century.